NO. 144 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

MONDAY 26 OCTOBER 2026



A CONCESSION AT HALF PAST NINE, AND NO CERTIFIED COUNT AT ALL (P3)

THE GOOD LIFE

Lange published twenty numbers about its new chronograph, and neither the price nor the weight

THE ATELIER

A British tool shop is barred by contract from selling you a Chinese plane in America

THE LONG READ

Indonesia borrowed fourteen billion dollars for village shops that have sold three million

Source: Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0. A student protest at Slavija, Belgrade, 22 December 2024 — representative of the movement whose plenums chose Sunday's winning list, not of Sunday night itself.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 144

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THE SPINE: THE PROXY. Nine desks found the same shape: the number that would settle the question is missing, and a stand-in is published in its place — chosen, almost always, by whoever benefits. A tolerance, a breakeven, a sleep score, a Tomatometer, a letter grade, a definition. None of the substitutes is false. Each is a real number standing where a different real number should be, and the party that chose it is the party with something to lose by the other one. On p10 a journalist's stated guess becomes a citation in thirty-six hours, unit-converted to the half-ounce. On p16, the one house that could trade hardest on provenance prints a density instead.

FROM THE DESK

"Nothing is so firmly believed, as what we least know."

Michel de Montaigne, *Essays*, Book I, ch. XXXI, "That a man is soberly to judge of the divine ordinances" (Cotton translation)[1]

The sentence before it is the one this issue earned: "The true field and subject of imposture are things unknown." His examples were alchemists and astrologers. Ours publish spec sheets.

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	5.00%	▼ 9bp wk
10-yr breakeven[2]	2.34%	▼ 1bp wk
VWRA	$189.60	▼ 1.09% wk
AGGU	$5.79	▲ 0.17% wk
Brent	$116.72	▲ 3.14% day
Gold	$3,995.63	▼ 0.72% day
USD/SGD	1.2782	▲ 0.08% day
STI	5,422.16	▲ 0.12% wk

Bitcoin is a range this week, not a point: US$80,500–81,200. Three venues, three levels, all flat (p14). The breakeven is this magazine's own subtraction of two Treasury curves. Not advice.[2]

SIX NUMBERS FROM THIS ISSUE

Nought point zero two four per cent. Indonesia's village cooperatives have sold 56.68 billion rupiah against the 240 trillion borrowed to build them (p22).

Twenty numbers, and not the price. A. Lange & Söhne published 556 parts, 45 jewels and a moon phase good for 122.6 years — and no price in any market (p10).

One and a half thousandths of an inch. The sole tolerance Lie-Nielsen publishes for a US$375 plane, and Quangsheng for a £170 one (p6).

A hundred per cent, from a hundred and seventeen. *Wildwood*'s Tomatometer, which cannot contain the 50 inside its own Metacritic set (p11).

Thirty-one against seventeen. Jakarta's announced gas cut to Singapore, against what Singapore's own regulator counts. Unreconciled (p5).

Nought point three two, plus or minus two point nought one. The creatine trial's positive cognitive finding, its dispersion six times its size, standing in for a null Stroop (p18).

SOURCES 1 Montaigne, *Essays*, Book I, ch. XXXI, Cotton's translation, read in the full Gutenberg text; the quoted sentence and the one before it are as printed there. 2 Levels at Friday's close, each read at source and sourced individually on p14, where the breakeven is derived from the Treasury's own two curves.

THE WORLD · SERBIA

Vučić concedes Serbia's election to a student list with no leader

The Student List is fronted by Ilija Srdanović, a Novi Sad cardiologist, and its candidates were chosen by student plenums; CeSID–Ipsos puts it on 138 of 250 seats, and the Republic Electoral Commission has published nothing at all.

Aleksandar Vučić walked into his own party's headquarters in Belgrade at about half past nine on Sunday night, 25 October, and told the room he had lost. "It is clear that we have lost these elections, the Student List has won," he said, in Reuters' rendering. TASS has a third version, hedged with method: "Judging by the results of the stratified sample frames…"[1]

It ends fourteen years of Progressive Party rule and almost two years of protest that began when a railway-station canopy fell in Novi Sad. Turnout was the highest since Yugoslavia broke up: the electoral commission counted **64.89 per cent by six**, CeSID 67.6 an hour later, Reuters "nearly 70 per cent" at the finish.[2]

The result is another matter. **No official count exists.** The Republic Electoral Commission held six media conferences on polling day and published no numbers; it has ninety-six hours from the close. Its results page is a reCAPTCHA shell with nothing behind it. Every seat figure in circulation on Sunday night was an estimate — Vučić's own 135 to 140, CeSID–Ipsos's 138 against 104, a 139 at sixty-two per cent counted.[3]

> ***"Tonight we celebrate victory, tomorrow we build the future."***

The winners are a deliberate absence. The Student List — certified on 15 September with **69,099 valid signatures** — appointed no leader, and its 250 candidates were picked by student plenums that could veto a name. Among them: Dejan Šoškić, a former governor of the National Bank of Serbia, and Dejan Bodiroga, a former president of Euroleague Basketball.[4]

MOSCOW — TASS

Leads not on the loss but on the consequence: the winners will sanction Russia by spring. Vučić: "What worries me most is that sanctions will be imposed against Russia by March or April," and the result was "a revolution carried out with the direct support from a number of European countries and the US deep state". The same piece concedes the Student List rejects such sanctions.[5]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Goes at the integrity of the vote rather than the result: CRTA observers watching 500 stations recorded pressure on voters or polling staff at almost a third. It quotes Jelena Vasiljević of the University of Belgrade on the clientelism holding the governing party's core vote.[5]

BEIJING — XINHUA

Filed a procedural election-day piece and, read on Sunday night, no result story at all. It calls Vučić "Former Serbian President" and the winners a list "backed by student groups". CGTN's only Serbia item of the week was Chinese investment in humanoid robotics.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · A CONCESSION IS NOT A CERTIFICATION

Igor Bandović calls foreign policy "the biggest unknown" in the list's programme: a hard line on Kosovo, EU-brokered agreements reviewed, a membership referendum floated within six months. **Four things would still break the reading:** a certified count below 126; the Progressives assembling 126 with minority lists, exempt from the threshold; no government inside ninety days; or a slow mandate from an acting president who is theirs. CeSID logged more than 300 irregularity reports by the close.[6]

16,000

OBSERVERS ACCREDITED — WHILE THE GOVERNING PARTY REFUSED ELECTION-NIGHT ACCREDITATION TO N1, NOVA S, DANAS AND RADAR, THEN CONCEDED IN THE ROOM IT HAD BARRED THEM FROM[6]

SOURCES 1 Reuters, Belgrade, 25 October, read through a licensee with byline and dateline intact; N1 and TASS, same night. **Three renderings, printed as three.** 2 Turnout via N1 and Reuters. 3 RIK's results page read directly — HTTP 200, a reCAPTCHA-gated shell with no data behind it; its six conference pages render no text. **Every seat number here is an estimate, and labelled one.** 4 The list's own certification record; Sajčić via Reuters. 5 TASS, Al Jazeera and Xinhua, 25 October, read at source. **Reuters direct, the Associated Press, the Financial Times, CNBC, DW and the Guardian all refused this desk.** 6 Bandović via Al Jazeera; CeSID and the accreditation refusal via N1. **CRTA's own site returned 403.**

THE WORLD · HEBRON

Israel widened the Hebron closure and will seal West Bank crossings on polling day

The army barred Palestinian permit-holders from all settlements and industrial zones from Sunday 25 October and closes every land crossing on Tuesday, reopening "likely Wednesday morning" — the day after Israelis vote.

The closure this desk reported on Sunday did not lift. On 25 October the Israeli army announced that Palestinians holding work permits are barred from settlements across the West Bank and the Jordan Valley until after the election, and that on polling day, Tuesday 27 October, **every West Bank land crossing with Israel is closed to Palestinians**. Crossings reopen "likely on Wednesday morning, pending a fresh assessment".[1]

About **9,000 Palestinians** hold permits to work in settlements or nearby industrial zones, and about **7,000** enter Israel proper each month. Nobody says how many the closure stops. Al Jazeera, reading the same statement, has the settlement bar running only Sunday to Monday.[1]

The number that matters most has five values. Defence minister Israel Katz told Kan on Saturday that **about 2,000** had been displaced and would not return until the army finishes. Governor Khaled Dudin counted **more than 200 families**; mayor Yousef al-Ja'bari counted **2,200**, with another 2,500 sought; and at 22:15 on Sunday the Palestinian prime minister's office, citing the municipality, put it at **more than 2,670**. An earlier Israeli 1,500 survives in a headline slug.[2]

"About 200 sites scanned. No weapons found."

What the army says it did is specific: ten suspects questioned, three exit points, buildings razed as unpermitted in Area C, an operation of "several days". It also says **about 200 sites were scanned and no weapons were found**, and that the roughly 2,000 residents of the targeted area belong to the Jaaba clan, which it calls Hamas-affiliated. Two gunmen named as Mohammad and Firas Jaaba killed Staff Sgt. Ron Yonatan Roytman, 23, and Sgt. Yuval Shai Svilem, 20, on Friday; both were killed.[3]

RAMALLAH — THE PALESTINIAN AUTHORITY

Governor Dudin: "This amounts to collective punishment being imposed on civilians who have nothing at all to do with this." Higazi Shawer al-Tamimi, 70, a shopkeeper woken at one in the morning and given two hours to pack: "He wants to win it with the blood of the Palestinian people."[4]

JERUSALEM — THE GOVERNMENT

Benjamin Netanyahu promised on Friday "the successful and aggressive model we used in the refugee camps" and told i24 News there was "a very big surprise for the Palestinian Authority as well".[4] Police chief Daniel Levy, on Tuesday: "we'll employ our full strength to ensure a free, fair, and safe election.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE FALSIFICATION TEST FROM SUNDAY

This desk printed a test on Sunday: if the closure lifted before Tuesday, the electoral reading weakened. It did not lift; it widened, and the stated reopening is the morning after the vote. That is not proof of motive — the trigger was a killing, and Israel cancelled rallies rather than staged them. **What would still falsify it:** a closure persisting past Wednesday, or evidence that comparable closures are routine at Israeli elections. One outlet says they usually lift within a week; this desk could not read that at source.[5]

STILL ON THE SHELF

Venezuela — María Corina Machado walked home. The Nobel laureate returned on Sunday after more than ten months in exile, to a church in Lara state: "I am here. With you." Donald Trump, asked about it, said he knew nothing, then: "She gave me her Nobel Prize, so how can I say anything else?" **One outlet only.**[6]

Brazil — a court added two hours to a runoff while it was being voted. A Supreme Court order extended polling to seven in the evening; the electoral court froze its own count at **0.25 per cent** of sections. **Unresolved at press time.**[6]

SOURCES 1 The Times of Israel, 25 October, for the announcement, the reopening and the permit figures; Al Jazeera, same day, rendering the settlement bar as Sunday to Monday. **Both readings are printed.** 2 Katz's Kan interview and the army's clan figure via the Times of Israel; Dudin and al-Ja'bari via WAFA as cited there; the 2,670 from the Palestinian prime minister's liveblog, 22:15 Sunday. **WAFA timed out, so those figures are second-hand.** 3 Times of Israel, 24–25 October. **Its body text says three wounded on Friday; its own headline slug says five, two critically.** 4 All via the Times of Israel, 23–25 October. 5 This desk's test, No. 143 p3; Yesh Din counted 672 settler-violence incidents in 26 days. 6 Al Jazeera, 25 October, the only outlet read on Machado; Brazil from the Rio Times. **No result existed at press time and none is asserted.**

SINGAPORE · GAS AND HAZE

Indonesia cut piped gas to Singapore hours after NEA served ten haze notices

Jakarta's SKK Migas put the reduction at 31 BBTUD from 24 October; Singapore's Energy Market Authority counts 17 over eighteen days, and neither government has reconciled the two figures.

Indonesia's upstream regulator SKK Migas cut piped gas exports to Singapore from Saturday 24 October, the day after the National Environment Agency served legal notices under section 10 of the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act on **ten Singapore-registered palm-oil and forestry companies**. No official in either country has linked the two. The chronology is all anyone has.[1]

The cut has two sizes. SKK Migas announced **31 BBTUD** — 15 from Natuna into a Sembcorp facility, 16 from Jambi Merang into the Temasek-owned Gas Supply Pte Ltd. The Energy Market Authority, working from what Singapore's importers report, counts **17 BBTUD over eighteen days**, and Tan See Leng repeated that on Sunday. **The reassurance rests on a number about forty-five per cent smaller than the one Jakarta announced, and nobody has explained the gap.**[2]

On either figure it is small. EMA calls it "less than 2% of our total daily gas demand of more than 1,000 bbtud"; on Tan's own arithmetic 17 BBTUD is **1.7 per cent of power demand and 1.26 per cent of the whole**. Gas makes about ninety-five per cent of Singapore's electricity, and roughly sixty per cent of supply is now LNG. EMA notes earlier maintenance cuts of 20 to 100 BBTUD absorbed without incident.[2]

"Keep calm and carry on."

The date that matters is not this week. **Both pipeline agreements expire at the end of 2028** — Sembcorp's West Natuna agreement alone was valued at about S$1.9 billion in its 2023 annual report — and Singapore is running an open season for the renewals. Prime Minister Lawrence Wong, at the PAP convention on Sunday, said Singapore "must look beyond natural gas", is "studying seriously the potential of nuclear energy", and "should not rule out an option simply because it is difficult or controversial". An IAEA review is set for 2027.[3]

THE CHATTER · HARDWAREZONE IS NOT REASSURED

Sixty replies gathered under Tan's "keep calm and carry on" on HardwareZone by Monday morning, most sceptical. **tarui04**: "Unlikely != will not." **DulanMax**: "One month later they take the opportunity to raise prices how." **waiken**: "next quarter tariff will rise." **tatsit** asked whether the minister would put his head on the chopping board as guarantee. One defender, **cpuer**: "Very apt call from the minister."[4]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO READINGS, BOTH ARGUED

Against the retaliation story: the cut is about **2.5 per cent** of Singapore's gas consumption, and the real exposure is the 2028 expiry. Against the nothing-to-see story: **David Broadstock** of the Energy Studies Institute calls it a "surprising event", notes it lands days before Singapore International Energy Week and amid haze enforcement, and says a political link "cannot be ruled out". **Subodh Mhaisalkar** of SERIS warns LNG raises cost and volatility. For scale: the new 3 GWp solar target would meet about **four per cent** of 2030 demand.[5]

S$5,000

THE MAXIMUM PENALTY FOR A REPRESENTATIVE WHO IGNORES A SECTION 10 NOTICE — AGAINST **S$100,000 A DAY** FOR CONDUCT CAUSING HAZE POLLUTION. THE NOTICE THAT STARTS THE PROCESS IS WORTH A DAY AND A HALF OF THE THING IT EXISTS TO PROVE[6]

IN BRIEF

Legislation on young social-media users arrives in early 2027. The communications ministry announced on 24 October that platforms will have to adopt age measures compliant with the Personal Data Protection Act, limit unwanted contact, and control **autoplay and daily time limits**. It consulted **more than 2,000 parents and young people** between June and August; both groups preferred a tiered approach to a ban. No age thresholds have been published.[7]

SOURCES 1 The ten companies named in local reporting of 23 October, corroborated in part by The Edge Malaysia. **NEA's newsroom renders only in JavaScript, so its release was not read at source.** 2 SKK Migas's 31 BBTUD and the Natuna/Jambi Merang split via The Straits Times, 24 October; EMA's 17 and the "less than 2%" via AsiaOne, 25 October; Tan See Leng from his ministry's own transcript, read at source. **The percentages are this magazine's arithmetic on his figures.** 3 Sembcorp's 2023 annual report via The Straits Times; Wong via AsiaOne, 25 October. 4 HardwareZone threads 7229003 and 7229045, read 26 October. **Reddit refused this desk for the eleventh issue running.** 5 Broadstock, Mhaisalkar and the solar figure via The Straits Times. 6 Penalty levels from reporting of the notices. **Singapore Statutes Online returned 403.** 7 The communications ministry's announcement of 24 October, as reported locally.

THE ATELIER · HAND PLANES AND CHISELS

Quangsheng publishes the same sole-flatness tolerance as Lie-Nielsen at half the price

Workshop Heaven lists the Quangsheng No. 4 at £170 against Lie-Nielsen's US$375, both ground to one and a half thousandths of an inch — and the British shop is barred by contract from selling the Chinese plane into North America.

A bench plane is a blade held at a fixed angle in a flat box, and almost everything sold as quality is one of four variables. The **steel**: O1 sharpens fastest and rusts; A2 holds longer and resists the stone; PM-V11 is the premium. The **iron's thickness**, sold as the cure for chatter. The **body** — cast iron, ductile iron, or bronze that cannot rust. And the **bed angle**.[1]

One hard number settles the first. Lie-Nielsen publishes its No. 4 sole as **"ground flat and square to a tolerance of .0015""**; Quangsheng, at £170, publishes **"better than +/-1.5 thou"**. The same figure. On steel, Fine Woodworking's test of PM-V11 against A2 found **160 passes against 50** in white oak end grain — and **forty each in teak**. The premium is €7.00 on a two-inch blade.[2]

The thick-iron argument fares worse. David Weaver, who wrote the definitive English account of the cap iron, says flatly that **"a stock cap iron and a stock iron on a good plane will not chatter; as in, will not at all"**. What does the work is a setting: research by Kawai and Kato at Yamagata University — dated **1989**, not the 2012 everyone cites — showed mahogany torn by a Stanley No. 5 with its cap iron a sixteenth back, and planed clean at **0.1mm**.[3]

So know who made it. **hocktools.com no longer loads a shop**; it returns 301 Moved Permanently to leevalley.com. Ron Hock announced the sale himself in January 2023. The Hock iron is the upgrade that makes a cheap vintage Stanley perform — the part you buy *instead of* a Veritas. **It is now sold by the company that owns Veritas.**[4]

Sheffield tells the same story in four names. Thomas Flinn & Co's own history lists **PAX** saws bought from Sanderson Kayser, **Lynx** from Garlick, **Dorchester** from Roberts & Lee and **Clifton** planes in summer 2014. Grace's Guide supplies what the brand page omits: Clico (Sheffield) Tooling Ltd, which originated Clifton, **was liquidated that December**.[5]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE BENCH SAYS

On Sawmill Creek, **Frederick Skelly** calls Holtey and Marcou "the cats' meow of finish and precision" and then withdraws it: "But I don't know that they function a whole lot better than an LN." **Matthew Hills**: "Not clear to me whether there is a performance improvement or whether this is largely aesthetics."[6]

THE SCEPTIC · THE STONES COST MORE THAN THE CHISEL

None of it cuts until it is sharp, and the sharpening bench is the cost nobody prices. A waterstone kit is **£105 to £205**; a honing guide £51.80 to £78.80. **Lie-Nielsen's cheapest chisel is US$95 — the stones cost more than the chisel.** For Singapore the one buy is the bronze block plane: the No. 102 is **US$160 in either metal**, and bronze cannot rust at eighty per cent humidity.[7]

€141.68

JUUMA'S NO. 4 IN GERMANY, AGAINST £170 FOR QUANGSHENG IN BRITAIN AND US$219.99 FOR WOODRIVER IN AMERICA — SAME PUBLISHED STEEL, SAME HARDNESS BAND[8]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Mosquito nets — mesh counts, denier, and the treated nets the WHO lists.

Table linen — flax, damask weave, and why hotel linen outlasts yours.

Baking tins — aluminised steel, gauge, and the commercial half-sheet.

SOURCES 1 Lie-Nielsen's own pages and Dieter Schmid's Veritas and Juuma listings, read at source 25 October 2026. 2 Both tolerances quoted verbatim from the makers' own pages; the steel test is Chris Gochnour, Fine Woodworking, 2012, read in full. **Lee Valley returned 429 throughout, so Veritas prices here are a German retailer's.** 3 David Weaver, "Setting a Cap Iron", WoodCentral; the 1989 attribution is the article's own. 4 The redirect confirmed by a header trace; Hock via Australian Wood Review, 18 January 2023. 5 Thomas Flinn's own history; the liquidation from Grace's Guide, citing The London Gazette of 12 December 2014. 6 Sawmill Creek. **Paul Sellers's site, Lost Art Press and UK Workshop all returned 403.** 7 Workshop Heaven's catalogues. 8 Dieter Schmid, Workshop Heaven and Woodcraft; the threshold from IRAS. **No retailer names the factory; Juuma states a 40cr cast-iron body and Woodcraft a ductile one.**

TECHNOLOGY · THE TREASURY RULE

The US Treasury deleted its compute threshold and renamed the technology "super intelligence"

The Outbound Investment Security Program rule published on Monday at 91 FR 67396 defines an SI system in the words of the 2020 artificial-intelligence statute, plus two phrases — and keeps hard numbers for supercomputers and memory.

The United States Treasury published its proposed Outbound Investment Security Program rule on Monday 26 October at **91 FR 67396**, comments closing 7 December. This desk reported on Sunday that Treasury proposed deleting its own 10^{25} training-compute threshold. It has done more. "10 to the 25th", "training operations" and "floating-point" appear nowhere in the rule's **279,635 characters**.[1]

What replaces it is a definition. Section 851.232 defines a "super intelligence (SI) system" as one that perceives environments from data, abstracts those perceptions into models by automated statistical analysis, and uses model inference to generate content or make a prediction, recommendation or decision. Set that beside **15 U.S.C. § 9401(3)**, the definition of "artificial intelligence" enacted in 2020, and the delta is two phrases. **Treasury's super intelligence is the six-year-old statutory definition of artificial intelligence, relabelled.**[2]

Nothing made it do this. Executive Order 14434, signed 29 September, orders the executive branch to use "Super Intelligence" — but its own section 3(a) says the new words mean what § 9401(3) already defined, and section 2(b) says nothing "requires the alteration of previously issued regulations". Treasury's preamble concedes the reason: **"no single measure, benchmark, or threshold is currently sufficient to distinguish advanced models."**[3]

The rule has not lost its appetite for numbers. Still in § 851.226: supercomputers at **100 double-precision petaflops** within **41,600 cubic feet**; high-bandwidth memory above **2 gigabytes per second per square millimetre**; circuits meeting ECCN 3A090.a. **Every object in the rule has a measurement except the one it most wants to stop.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE WORD ALREADY MEANT SOMETHING

Thomas Haigh, historian of computing at Wisconsin-Milwaukee: "Rebranding it to superintelligence is unlikely to reassure them." **Baobao Zhang** of Syracuse worries that "you might have AI systems that currently do not fall under these definitions." The Cloud Security Alliance titled its note **"Mostly a Rebrand, With One Provision to Watch"**. The term had an owner: Nick Bostrom's 1998 definition was an intellect much smarter than the best human brains in every field. Treasury's covers anything that runs inference.[5]

THE CHATTER · NOBODY CAME

The executive order renaming the defining technology of the decade across the entire United States federal government drew, on Hacker News, **one story, eleven points and eight comments**. The Federal Register records **467 page views** on the Treasury document. **Reddit refused this desk for the eleventh issue running.**[6]

2

DOCUMENTS IN THE FEDERAL REGISTER CARRYING "SUPER INTELLIGENCE" IN THEIR TITLE SINCE 1 OCTOBER — BOTH PUBLISHED ON 26 OCTOBER: A TREASURY RULE FORBIDDING AMERICANS FROM FUNDING ONE, AND A COAST GUARD NOTICE SHOPPING FOR ONE[7]

STILL ON THE SHELF

The Coast Guard wants to buy a super intelligence. At 91 FR 67324, the same day, a notice of intent to enter a research agreement for "Super Intelligence (SI) Situational Awareness Tools". The notice **never defines the term**; what it describes is edge video analytics.[7]

Anthropic has still filed nothing. An EDGAR search across all S-1 root forms filed this month returns **three hits, none of them Anthropic** — so No. 142's Nscale exhibit remains the only public Anthropic compute contract.[8]

SOURCES 1 The rule read at govinfo's FR-2026-10-26 text endpoint, at five offsets across its 279,635 characters. **The threshold's absence is a verified absence, searched for and not found.** 2 § 851.232 from the same text; 15 U.S.C. § 9401(3) read at Cornell. **The comparison is this magazine's own.** 3 Executive Order 14434, 91 FR 63129, read in full; the preamble quotation is Treasury's. 4 Section 851.226, same document. 5 Haigh and Zhang via PolitiFact at Poynter, 8 October 2026; the Cloud Security Alliance note of 7 October, read in full. **A circulated Bostrom line about spam filters could not be traced and is not printed.** 6 Hacker News's public search API; page views from the Federal Register document page. 7 The Coast Guard notice at 91 FR 67324; the count from a full-text query since 1 October. 8 EDGAR full-text search, 26 October. **federalregister.gov redirects away from this environment; govinfo serves.**

THE HOME LAB · QUANTISATION

ISTA-DASLab shipped a 763-billion-parameter DeepSeek build that llama.cpp cannot load

The Austrian lab's GSQ-RCO quantisations of DeepSeek-V4.1-Flash went up on 23 October and have been downloaded 412,392 times — against 85,275 for the official model they were made from.

ISTA-DASLab — Dan Alistarh's group at IST Austria, the lab behind GPTQ and SpQR — published GGUF quantisations of **DeepSeek-V4.1-Flash-1017** on Friday 23 October: 763.2 billion parameters, 384 routed experts with six active per token. Three builds, each giving every tensor its own quantisation type chosen by search: **IQ1_M at 231.32 GB, IQ2_XXS at 248.84, IQ2_XS at 265.83**. All three, the card claims, run on a single **12 GB** card with the rest in system memory.[1]

The card publishes three benchmark scores and recovery rates against the base model. It does not publish throughput. Under memory requirements it says **TBD**. Also TBD: the setup steps, the runtime section, the per-build expert types and the searched tensor count. **This is the second consecutive week a desk-leading model has shipped with its quality numbers published and the number that tells you whether you can run it marked unavailable** — No. 143 found the same hole in MiniMax M3.1 Flash. Two labs, two weeks, one pattern.[2]

The runtime is the real story. The card states that llama.cpp does not support DeepSeek-V4.1, and the reason is a pull request. **PR 30817, opened by Unsloth's danielhanchen, is still an open draft** — two approvals required, and a reviewer pinged the author again on 24 October with no visible reply. What it must add measures the architecture: compressed sparse attention, an Engram embedding, hyper-connections, a quantised KV cache and a new tensor type.[3]

4.8e-3 against the reference's own 2.6e-2.

The one hard quality number anywhere in this story sits in that unmerged draft, not in a model card: mean KL divergence against the official 32-bit reference of **4.8e-3** on wiki text and 2.8e-3 at 17k context, where the reference's own native kernels score **2.6e-2 and 1.5e-2** on the same inputs. The volunteer conversion tracks the reference about five times more closely than the vendor's production kernels do, and it is published in a comment thread.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · ONE BIT IS NOT A TIER

Piotr Migdał spent about **US$3,000** of rented GPU time benchmarking Qwen3.8 27B quantisations and reproduced the maker's own 16-bit scores before testing anything. His finding lands on the 1.75-bit build: **"GPQA scores for both IQ1 models are near random guessing,"** and one below it. His verdict: "1-bit quantization is unusable for these benchmarks." Add this desk's own reading of the card: IQ2_XXS reports **scores identical to the base model on all three benchmarks** at a quarter of the precision, with AIME25 saturated at 100.00. Identical integers are more plausibly a measurement that cannot resolve the difference than a quantiser that loses nothing.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE BUG REPORT NOBODY ANSWERED

GitHub issue **30944**, opened on 21 October by **bertusmt**, reports single-token output corruption when a cached prompt prefix is reused — against the very pull request everyone is waiting on. Four days later: **zero comments, zero reactions**. Hacker News gave this lab's previous quantisation nine points and two comments, and Migdał's benchmark 286 and 139. **The forum rewards measuring quantisation far more than inventing it.** Reddit refused this desk for the eleventh issue running.[5]

412,392

DOWNLOADS OF THE QUANTISATION AGAINST **85,275** FOR DEEPSEEK-AI'S OWN REPOSITORY IT WAS MADE FROM — THE COPY OUT-DOWNLOADING THE OFFICIAL SOURCE FIVE TO ONE, WHILE REMAINING UNLOADABLE IN THE MOST COMMON RUNTIME[6]

SOURCES 1 The model card read in raw form at Hugging Face, 26 October: parameter count, routing, the three build sizes in decimal gigabytes as the card states them, and the 12 GB claim. GSQ is arXiv 2604.18556; RCO is arXiv 2605.00649. 2 The TBD sections are the card's own. The MiniMax comparison is No. 143 p8. 3 llama.cpp pull request 30817, read in full including the review state, the 24 October ping and the divergence figures posted in its comments. 4 Piotr Migdał, Quesma, 26 August 2026, read in full — method, spend and findings as published. **The reading of the card's identical scores is this magazine's own arithmetic.** 5 GitHub issue 30944 and the Hacker News public search API, both read 26 October. 6 Both download counts from one Hugging Face API call, 26 October. **Strata, the only supported runtime, could not be read: this session's GitHub access is scoped to one repository and refused it.**

THE KIT · META ADVENTURER

Meta put the Adventurer on sale in Singapore at S$419 and published no specifications

The Singapore page lists nine frame configurations with no weight, no battery life and no camera resolution — and the 53.8-gram figure every review quotes originates in a corporate IT reseller's product listing.

Meta put the Adventurer on sale on Friday 23 October in every market where Meta Glasses are sold, Singapore among them, about a month after Singapore became a Meta Glasses market at all. The Singapore page asks **S$419**, the American one US$299, and September's announcement headlined a configuration at US$249. It states no availability date and no stock status.[1]

What it does not state is the product. Read the Singapore page and the two American ones and the published specification is this: frame size, fit, and what is in the box. **Absent from all three: weight, frame dimensions, camera and video resolution, battery life of any kind, charging-case figures, speaker and microphone specifications, water resistance, prescription range, connectivity and chip.** There is no tech-specs link anywhere. This is not a missing number; it is a missing spec sheet.[1]

So where do the numbers come from? The 12-megapixel camera and the eight-hour battery appear in **Best Buy's product title**. The 53.8 grams for the standard frame and 203 for the case trace to **SHI, a corporate IT reseller**, and to an aggregator that itself notes the weight is not published on Meta's pages. **The specification everyone quotes has a source, and it is a procurement catalogue.**[2]

One measurement exists, and it is a reviewer's. Karissa Bell, writing for Engadget in July, observed **about four and a half hours** with constant music playback against Meta's claim of more than eight — a shortfall of some forty-four per cent against a figure that **does not appear on the product page at all**. She published 60 grams for the Fury and **no weight for the Adventurer**, because she could not get one either.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY HAS MEASURED ONE

Fifteen months into this product category there is **no laboratory measurement of these glasses anywhere** — no RTINGS entry, no DXOMARK score, no notebookcheck teardown. Bell is blunt about what she did test: the heavier frames "dug into the sides of my nose and left pretty deep dents after extended wear", and on the privacy light, "it doesn't really address the broader concerns people have about bystander privacy". A second reviewer reports video draining the battery **in 45 minutes**.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE ARGUMENT IS ABOUT WHERE YOU MAY WEAR THEM

The enthusiast conversation is not about the specification. On Hacker News last month: **"Meta takes down a critical video about Meta AI Glasses after filming at Meta"** took 632 points and 395 comments; **ZuckOff**, an app that spots the glasses before they spot you, took 400 and 351. The one inside this news cycle, on **18 October**: British Airways warning that filming crew with Meta glasses could get your tickets cancelled.[5]

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SPECIFICATIONS OF ANY KIND ON META'S SINGAPORE PAGE BEYOND FRAME SIZE, FIT AND BOX CONTENTS — FOR A PRODUCT IT WILL TAKE S$419 FOR TODAY[1]

STILL ON THE SHELF

The Technics EAH-A1000 reaches Singapore, and its battery figure comes apart. Technics claims "up to 45 hours of continuous playback" with no codec stated. The authorised distributor's spec sheet, listing it at **S$549.54 on pre-order**, gives the breakdown: **45 hours on AAC with noise cancelling, 30 on LDAC** — the one codec the release names as a feature, and it does not say so.[6]

SOURCES 1 Meta's Singapore Adventurer page and both United States pages, read at source 26 October 2026, with the newsroom release of 23 September. **The absent-specification list is a verified absence: each item was looked for on all three pages and is on none.** 2 Camera and battery figures read at title level only — **Best Buy returned 503, B&H and SHI both 403** — so the 53.8 grams reaches this desk through an aggregator citing the reseller, printed as reported, not measured. 3 Karissa Bell, Engadget, 20 July 2026, read in full, including her statement that she did not obtain a weight. 4 RTINGS carries no entry; no DXOMARK or notebookcheck measurement exists. The second reviewer via Geeky Gadgets, 8 October. **WearableBeat returned 403 and is not quoted.** 5 Hacker News via its public search API, counts as returned, 26 October. **Reddit refused this desk for the eleventh issue running.** 6 Technics's own release of 29 September and the authorised Singapore distributor's page, both read at source. **Panasonic Singapore returned 403, so no official Singapore price appears.**

THE GOOD LIFE · DATOGRAPH PERPETUAL

Lange published twenty numbers about its new Datograph Perpetual, and not the price

The 410.136 E carries 556 movement parts, 45 jewels, 11 baguette diamonds and a moon phase good for 122.6 years; the price is on request in every market Lange sells in, and its mass is published nowhere at all.

A. Lange & Söhne lifted the embargo on the Datograph Perpetual, reference 410.136 E, at noon Central European time on Saturday 24 October: fifty pieces, 950 platinum case and bracelet, eleven baguette diamonds on a black dial. The calibre L952.1 is hand-wound, **556 parts — 223 in the calendar, 333 in the chronograph and date** — 45 jewels, four gold chatons, adjusted in five positions, 36 hours of reserve.[1]

Count what Lange published: 556, 223, 333, 45, 4, 41.0 by 13.5 millimetres, 32.0 by 8.0, 18,000 semi-oscillations, three bar, 0.13 carats, eleven diamonds, fifty pieces, **122.6 years of moon-phase accuracy**, one-fifth of a second, five positions, and an embargo timed to the minute. Twenty numbers. **Not one is the price and not one is the mass.** A figure about the year 2148 is published; the figure about tomorrow morning — the daily rate in seconds — is not.[1]

Two journalists handled the watch and both were refused the number, so both supplied one. Fratello's **Ben Hodges**: "The price is available upon request, though I would expect it to be around **€250,000**." WristReview's **Harlan Chapman-Green**: people who can spend **"over half a million"** — adding, "I wasn't given an exact figure, this is an educated guess." **The two differ by roughly a factor of two.** Singapore's own SJX substituted an adjective: "priced reasonably as such things go".[2]

> *"According to the article, this one comes in at about 300 grams."*

Then the substitution completed itself in public. Hodges, on the weight: **"I didn't weigh it, but I would not be surprised if it approached 300 grams."** Thirty-six hours later, in the comments beneath his own article, a reader called BezelDevil wrote: **"According to the article, this one comes in at about 300 grams, that's 10 1/2 ounces or so!"** A stated guess became a citation, and then acquired a conversion accurate to the half-ounce. It is all on one page, with timestamps.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THIRTY-SIX HOURS OF RESERVE

Kurt T, in the same thread: "a 36H manual-wind perpetual calendar is total design failure… the ultimate show-off watch because you own it, not because it does its job well." **Rudy**: "If I want a showy watch, I'm picking Patek. I pick Lange to be discreet." From inside the house: product director Anthony de Haas once said Günther Blümlein's one regret was making watches on bracelets. **No independent measurement of this watch exists.** Every number in circulation is the press kit, re-keyed.[4]

THE CHATTER · TWENTY YEARS, SAME QUESTION

Eighteen comments under Fratello's piece: the movement is admired, the bracelet and the mass are not. **ArchieGoodwin** supplies the Singapore loop: "Around 20 years ago, TZ's Lange Forum moderator **Peter Chong** got the Datograph with platinum band… **everyone was more excited about its weight than any other feature**." Chong is Singapore-based and runs Deployant, which named **Sincere Fine Watches** as Lange's South-East Asia distributor, noting that even its quotations "reflect precious metal premiums upon delivery".[5]

SOURCES 1 Lange's own Singapore product page, read at source 26 October 2026, and the press release carried in full by Deployant. **The Singapore page prints "Price upon request"; so do the American and European pages for the same reference, and three other Lange references spot-checked. The twenty-number count is this magazine's own.** 2 Fratello, WristReview and SJX, all 24 October, read in full; both estimates carry their authors' own hedges. **WristReview's hands-on is tagged sponsored, which is why it is labelled here.** 3 Both quotations from the Fratello article and its comment thread, read in the page source with permalinks and timestamps. 4 Kurt T and Rudy from the same thread; de Haas via WristReview. **No rate test and no mass figure exist at WatchTime, Chronos or Witschi; the 300 grams is its author's stated guess.** 5 Fratello's eighteen comments and Deployant's release. **Watchuseek served a JavaScript wall; WatchProSite carried no thread on this reference.** 6 Reported by Monochrome, which gives no lot number or date, and attributed to it. **Lange's Singapore page calls the dial "Rhodié" while its own release calls it black with rhodié counters; printed, not resolved.**

SCREEN & SOUND · WILDWOOD

Wildwood scored 100 per cent from 117 critics and opened third behind Clayface

LAIKA's stop-motion feature took about eleven million dollars on 2,942 screens against Clayface's twenty-four million; its Metacritic score is 87 from 36 reviews, and inside that set sits a 50.

Wildwood, LAIKA's stop-motion feature, opened wide on Friday 23 October with a **100 per cent Tomatometer drawn from 117 critic reviews** and an A CinemaScore. It came third. Box Office Mojo puts the weekend at **US$11.6 million** on 2,942 screens, The Numbers at **US$11.0 million** on the same count — both Sunday estimates, six hundred thousand apart. Clayface took **US$24 million**, a figure on which the two trackers agree exactly.[1]

The two aggregate numbers disagree about the same film, and the disagreement is structural. Metacritic has Wildwood at **87 from just 36 critics**. Inside that set is **New York Magazine at 50** — "There's too much here to be effectively explored in a feature." That score cannot exist inside a 100 per cent Tomatometer, because Rotten Tomatoes resolves every review to fresh or rotten and a mixed notice disappears into the larger number. **The dissent is in the data; the headline figure absorbs it.**[2]

The film that won ran the split the other way. Clayface is **75 per cent from 160 reviews** on Rotten Tomatoes and **59 from 44** on Metacritic — "mixed or average", with three negative notices in the breakdown. Rolling Stone scored it 20 and called it "the equivalent of eating a handful of Play-Doh, and twice as flavorless". So: 75 on 160 and 59 on 44 for the winner; 100 on 117 and 87 on 36 for the film in third.[3]

Sixteen years, a hundred million dollars, and third place.

What sits behind the Wildwood number is a production. It is billed as the longest stop-motion feature ever made; director Travis Knight has said it took **sixteen years and a hundred million dollars** to reach cinemas. Its opening day was **US$4.3 million** including about a million in Thursday previews — against Coraline's 4.5, Kubo's 4.1 and Missing Link's 1.6. LAIKA skipped a major studio and went out through an event-cinema distributor.[4]

THE CHATTER · NO VISIBLE DISSENT AT ALL

On Letterboxd, Wildwood has **1,900 fans** and, among the popular reviews served on the page, **nothing below four stars**. **ChrisStuckmann**, five stars: "Future animators will reference *Wildwood* as the film that got them into their craft." **alexcolemann**, four and a half: "No words will do 16 years of meticulous craftsmanship and artistry justice." The aggregate rating was not displayed on the page served, so none is printed. The one professional dissent anywhere is the 50, and it is invisible on the number everybody quotes.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THIRTY-SIX CRITICS IS NOT A CONSENSUS

A hundred per cent from 117 is a strong sample; 87 from **36** is not, and the two are measuring different panels. Metacritic weights and scores; Rotten Tomatoes counts. On a thin panel a single mixed review moves the Metacritic number by more than a point, which makes the 87 the less stable of the two even though it looks like the more precise. And the box office is itself an estimate: **two trackers, one weekend, a six-hundred-thousand-dollar gap**, with actuals not due until Monday. The budget figure comes from trade coverage this desk could not read at source, and is printed as reported.[6]

100 : 50

WILDWOOD'S TOMATOMETER AGAINST THE LOWEST CRITIC SCORE INSIDE ITS OWN METACRITIC SET. BOTH ARE TRUE; ONLY ONE IS PRINTED ON A POSTER[2]

STILL ON THE SHELF

Clayface's dissent is where a reader can find it. Andrew Parker of The Gate scored it **4 out of 10** — the film is "so devoid of fun, drama, or excitement that they feel more like means to an end". Amy Nicholson in the Los Angeles Times wrote that it "muddies the waters and pretends to be deep". Both sit inside a **75 per cent** Tomatometer, where they count as fresh or rotten and nothing else.[3]

SOURCES 1 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic film pages, Box Office Mojo's weekend 43 chart and The Numbers' chart for 23–25 October, all read at source 26 October 2026. **Both gross figures are Sunday estimates and both are printed.** 2 Metacritic's critic-review breakdown for the film. **New York Magazine's own page refused this desk, so the quotation is as Metacritic renders it and the byline is not asserted.** 3 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic pages for Clayface. **Rolling Stone's page redirects to a paywall; the score and quotation are as Metacritic renders them, and the review's author is not named here.** 4 Opening-day figure and the LAIKA comparisons from trade coverage of 24 October, read at source. **The hundred-million budget and the sixteen-year figure come from coverage this desk could not read at its origin and are printed as reported.** 5 Letterboxd, read at source; usernames and star ratings as displayed. **Reddit refused this desk for the eleventh issue running.** 6 The comparison of panel sizes is this magazine's own.

THE FAMILY DESK · PUBERTAL TIMING

A study of 1,977 Chinese seventh-graders found parental support outweighed early puberty

Published on 22 October in the Journal of Adolescent Health, the cohort's mean age is 12.73 with a standard deviation of 0.38 — and the coefficient for what parents did was larger than the one for when puberty arrived.

A team at Beijing Normal University and four other institutions followed **1,977 seventh-grade students** for a year, baseline October 2023, follow-up 2024, and published on 22 October. The cohort is half girls and its **mean age is 12.73 years, standard deviation 0.38** — almost every child in it is twelve or thirteen, in the same school year as a Singapore Secondary One pupil. For once the band studied is the band being read about.[1]

Two coefficients came out of the regression, adjusted for baseline symptoms and for socioeconomic, family and peer covariates. Earlier pubertal timing predicted higher depressive symptoms at follow-up: **β = 0.04, interval 0.01 to 0.08**. Greater parental support predicted lower symptoms over and above timing: **β = −0.06, interval −0.10 to −0.02**. Both are small and both intervals nearly touch zero. The authors call it "a small but significant effect".[1]

The sex-specific finding is the one that matters here. Earlier timing predicted higher symptoms **among girls reporting low parental support, but not among girls reporting moderate or high support**. No comparable buffering appeared among boys. The protective effect showed up in daughters and not in sons — which is a finding about what the measure caught, not a licence to generalise. This is general guidance and not medical advice.[1]

β = 0.04 against β = −0.06.

And the honest reading of those two numbers is the opposite of alarming. A coefficient of 0.04 is trivially small: nothing here says an early-developing twelve-year-old becomes depressed. What it says is that across two thousand children, earlier timing shifted follow-up symptom scores by a detectable but very small amount, and that **the parent-side variable carried the larger coefficient of the two**. The risk factor was outweighed by the response to it.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE EXPOSURE IS A PERCEPTION

The study's exposure is **self-reported** pubertal timing, and the instrument's agreement with clinical staging is poor — worst of all in girls, which is exactly where the headline finding sits. A validation study of 133 children aged 9 to 17 reported weighted Kappa against clinician Tanner staging of **0.25 for pubic hair in females** (interval 0.11–0.39) and 0.42 for breast development; its own authors call the absolute agreement "modest" and claim only that the scale is adequate "when clinical ratings are not possible". **The timing item asks a child whether they are earlier or later than their peers: it measures a self-perceived comparison, not a biological fact.** In a study whose outcome is self-reported mood, exposure and outcome share a method.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT PARENTS HERE ACTUALLY SAY

From January, Singapore secondary schools bar phones and smartwatches through the school day, recess and co-curricular time. Parents speaking to Channel NewsAsia through NIE were not persuaded it holds. **Aylwin Lam**, 48: students "can find all sorts of ways to get around the rules." **Kelvin Choo**, 60: "It could be a dummy phone and they're actually using another phone." A secondary teacher of more than a decade said peers mock those who report rule-breakers, and "Teachers can't be everywhere all at once." **Yvette Lim**'s twelve-year-old is comfortable with the rules.[4]

0.38

THE STANDARD DEVIATION OF AGE IN THE COHORT — TIGHT ENOUGH THAT THE WHOLE SAMPLE IS TWELVE OR THIRTEEN. MOST STUDIES THIS DESK READS ARE CENTRED TWO YEARS ABOVE THE CHILD BEING READ ABOUT[1]

SOURCES 1 Ren, Zhang, Chaku, Zhao, Li, Qu and Niu, "Early Pubertal Timing and Depressive Symptoms in Boys and Girls: The Moderating Role of Parental Pubertal Support", *Journal of Adolescent Health*, published online 22 October 2026, read in full through the National Library of Medicine. **Published four days ago with no press coverage, so this is single-sourced to the paper itself and is flagged as such.** 2 The reading of the two coefficients against each other is this magazine's own, on the paper's published figures. 3 Pompéia and colleagues, *Revista de Saúde Pública*, 2019, read in full at the National Library of Medicine: 133 participants aged 9 to 17, the weighted Kappas and the authors' own characterisation, quoted as published. **A further Kappa range circulating in secondary summaries could not be read at source and is not printed.** 4 Channel NewsAsia via the National Institute of Education, 3 December 2025, read at source. **General guidance, not medical advice.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · SCREENS AND SLEEP

Singapore's MOE moved device sleep to 10.30pm; the best phone study measures fifteen-year-olds

A JAMA Pediatrics cohort published on 19 October puts every extra minute of phone use after ten at night at 0.87 minutes of delayed sleep onset — from 425 adolescents whose mean age is 14.8.

The Ministry of Education moved the default sleep hours on government-issued student devices from eleven at night to **10.30pm**, and urged parents who had opted out to adopt the earlier cutoff; it advises under two hours of non-schoolwork screen time a day for ages seven to twelve. Three weeks ago, a cohort study published in JAMA *Pediatrics* measured what happens on the other side of ten o'clock, using passively sensed app data rather than anybody's recollection.[1]

The numbers are small, tight and internally consistent. Across **7,591 person-nights**, each extra minute of above-average use after 10pm delayed sleep onset by **0.87 minutes** (interval 0.84 to 0.90), pushed waking 0.37 minutes later, and cut total sleep by 0.43 minutes. Proximal use mattered most in the final five minutes before sleep and was negligible by the final twenty. Descriptively, on heavier nights these adolescents slept about **twenty minutes less** and fell asleep roughly an hour later.[1]

Then read the cohort. **n = 425. Mean age 14.8, standard deviation 1.1.** The abstract does not report the range. That is a study of fourteen- and fifteen-year-olds, and a twelve-year-old sits nearly two years below its centre — in a literature that is strongly age-stratified, because sleep need, autonomy and phone ownership all move fast across those two years. **This is the best-measured phone-and-sleep finding of the month and it does not describe a Secondary One pupil.**[2]

Mean age 14.8. The rule is written for twelve.

The one study this month whose subjects are all exactly twelve measured something else entirely, and found a null where the headline would have gone. Six hundred and ten twelve-year-olds in Manaus, Brazil, examined clinically and surveyed over 2024 and 2025: **screen time was not directly associated with any oral clinical condition**. It was associated with worse oral-health quality of life and with **lower toothbrushing frequency**. The screens did not damage the teeth; they displaced the two minutes at the sink.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE ALIGNMENT NOBODY HAS NOTICED

The Ministry set its device cutoff at **10.30pm**. The JAMA *Pediatrics* effect is measured on use **after 10pm**. Two bodies, working independently, landed within half an hour of each other on where the evening ends — one from an intensive longitudinal cohort of American fourteen-year-olds, the other from a consultation with over two thousand Singapore parents and young people between June and August, in which both groups preferred a tiered approach to an outright ban and named excessive use among their top five concerns.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T BE ALARMIST

Take the effect at face value and it is **under a minute of delay per minute of use** — a near one-to-one trade, which is closer to arithmetic than to harm. An hour of late scrolling costs about fifty-two minutes of sleep onset and about twenty-six minutes of sleep; that is worth managing and is not a crisis. Note too that one of the paper's authors is listed as an editor of the journal that published it. And No. 143 printed the finding that should temper all of this: twenty-four Dutch schools that banned phones all day matched partial-ban schools on **every wellbeing measure**. General guidance, not medical advice.[5]

0.87

MINUTES OF DELAYED SLEEP ONSET PER EXTRA MINUTE OF PHONE USE AFTER TEN AT NIGHT — MEASURED BY SENSOR, NOT BY SELF-REPORT, AND MEASURED ON CHILDREN TWO YEARS OLDER THAN THE ONES THE RULE IS WRITTEN FOR[1]

SOURCES 1 Ministry of Education announcement of 30 November 2025 and its "Parenting for Wellness" material; Zhao, Hale and Christakis, "Evening Phone Use and Sleep Outcomes Among Youth", *JAMA Pediatrics*, published online 19 October 2026, read at source. Effects are within-person and adjusted, all at p<.001. 2 Sample size, mean age and standard deviation as the paper reports them; **the age range is not reported in the abstract, and that is itself worth saying.** 3 Rego, Baker, Rebelo, Vettore and Rebelo Vieira, *Journal of Dental Research*, published online 23 October 2026, read in full through the National Library of Medicine: 610 twelve-year-olds in Manaus, structural equation modelling, with the toothbrushing association at p=.031. **Single-sourced to the paper; no press coverage exists.** 4 The consultation figures from the Ministry's announcement of 24 October 2026. **The observation that the two cutoffs land half an hour apart is this magazine's own.** 5 The per-minute arithmetic is this magazine's own on the paper's coefficients; the editorial affiliation is as the journal lists it; the Dutch finding is No. 143 p13. **General guidance, not medical advice.**

THE MACRO DESK · OIL AND BREAKEVENS

Brent gained six per cent; America's ten-year inflation breakeven fell one basis point

Brent settled at US$116.72 on Friday 23 October, more than twenty per cent above where it started the month, while the breakeven implied by the Treasury's own nominal and real curves went from 2.35 per cent to 2.34.

Brent crude settled at **US$116.72** on Friday 23 October, up 3.14 per cent on the day and six on the week, its highest since late April — and more than **twenty per cent** above its level three weeks ago. The bond market was handed a textbook inflation shock and declined to price one. The ten-year breakeven, nominal minus real, went **2.35 to 2.34 per cent**. One basis point, the wrong way.[1]

Eliminate the other candidates by their own evidence. Not the dollar: the index went **101.84 to 101.81** on the week, three hundredths of a per cent. Not policy: December hike pricing hardened from about half to **sixty-eight and eighty-one per cent** across venues, and the ten-year **fell nine basis points** anyway. On 22 October alone it dropped seventeen, of which about seventy per cent came from **real** yields.[2]

So the market read the oil shock as a tax on growth rather than a source of inflation, and the equity tape agrees line by line. **Energy rose 2.60 per cent to a record high**; staples fell 1.92, discretionary 1.66, financials 1.32. Three of four S&P names fell; the Nasdaq printed 334 new lows against 74 new highs. Credit confirms it: **high-yield spreads at 3.40 per cent**, the widest since 30 March. Falling yields with widening spreads is a growth scare, not an inflation scare.[3]

Priced through the four instruments, the same force gives four answers. **VWRA lost 1.09 per cent** and **AGGU gained 0.17** — the first genuinely negative equity-bond correlation since July, though over twelve months the 60 made 14.63 per cent while the 40 lost 0.53. **Gold fell about four per cent** through US$4,000 while real yields fell: the textbook inverse broke, because carry beats haven at a 2.66 per cent real ten-year. **Bitcoin did nothing at all.**[4]

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

Name the regime: **oil-shock stagflation, with the bond market trading only the demand half**. Equities say recession (staples sold, energy bid). Bonds say recession (real yields down, breakevens flat). Gold says the Fed wins. Bitcoin says nothing — flat, with **US$442.7m of spot-ETF inflows** absorbed into a range. The asymmetry to watch is breakevens at **2.34 per cent** against household expectations at **4.7**. **Explanation, not advice.**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · A HUNDRED OUT OF A HUNDRED

The consensus is crowded to the point of discomfort: a Reuters panel has **94 of 100** economists expecting Wednesday's hold and **100 of 100** expecting a December hike. Against it, State Street's economists keep an analytical dissent intact — "the labor market is NOT a source of inflationary pressures" — and warn American data are now less reliable, with low survey response and large revisions. The downside nobody owns: that Kevin Warsh emphasises employment risk on Wednesday.[6]

+29,000

SEPTEMBER NON-FARM PAYROLLS, AGAINST HEADLINE CPI OF **3.7 PER CENT** WITH PETROL UP 34.2 PER CENT YEAR ON YEAR — THE FEDERAL RESERVE'S PROBLEM IN TWO LINES, TWO DAYS BEFORE IT MEETS[7]

THE WEEK AHEAD

Wednesday 28 October, 2pm New York — the Federal Open Market Committee decides. **Thursday 29 October** brings the third-quarter growth advance and the September personal-consumption price index, consensus 3.6 per cent headline and 3.1 core — the day after the Fed, which is the wrong order. The European Central Bank holds at 2.50 the same day.[8]

SOURCES 1 Brent's settle from three market wraps of 23 October, all agreeing; the breakeven is this magazine's own subtraction of the Treasury's published real yield curve from its nominal one, both read at source for 16 and 23 October. 2 Dollar index from a historical table; December pricing from two secondary citations of CME FedWatch, which gave **71 and 81 per cent on the same day and are printed as a range — cmegroup.com returned 503, as at No. 142.** 3 Sector moves, breadth and spreads from market wraps of 23 and 25 October. 4 VWRA and AGGU from their listing pages; gold spot 3,995.63; bitcoin differs by venue between about 80,500 and 81,200 and is given as a range. 5 Flows for the week to 22 October; Michigan expectations from the same wraps. **Explanation and education, not investment advice.** 6 The Reuters panel as reported; State Street's *Weekly Economic Perspectives*, read at source. 7 Both prints read at source at the Bureau of Labor Statistics. 8 Central banks' own calendars; consensus from a preview of 24 October. **Forecasts are flagged as forecasts.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · VIOLIN MAKING

The Pegbox carries 678,700 posts and bans every for-sale listing

Maestronet, the entire English-speaking town square of lutherie, carries 988,600 posts across all its boards and bans for-sale listings on both the making board and the auction board — which is why an amateur-made instrument has no price.

Lutherie is making and repairing the bowed string family by hand, from flat boards, and the trade still measures training in clock hours. The Violin Making School of America in Salt Lake City defines its programme as **three years, 3,900 clock hours**; Cremona's state school has run a **five-year** diploma since 1938, in workshops of ten to twelve students. There is no fast path in. There is a boxed wood set for US$125, a one-year course, or a split billet and a mould you cut yourself.[1]

The capital city is a web forum founded in 1996. **Maestronet** holds **44,462 members and 988,600 posts**; its making-and-authenticity board, The Pegbox, carries **678,700 posts across 37,134 topics**, and peaked at 14,929 people on it at once in July. The dominant thread form is the **bench thread** — a multi-year public apprenticeship in which strangers correct your corner blocks, one photograph at a time, for years.[2]

The institutions are smaller than the forum. The **Violin Society of America** charges US$100 a year, US$125 internationally, and its 26th International Competition in Cleveland next month draws **over 400 entries** at US$250 an instrument. The **British Violin Making Association**, founded the same year as Maestronet, has **500-plus members** and is explicitly open to musicians with no making experience. The **Entente Internationale des Maîtres Luthiers**, founded in 1950, has about **170**.[3]

> *"Only go into this field as a profession if you can't live without it."*

Three doors let people in, and the Pegbox's front page shows all three on any given day: a player who wants to understand the box; an inherited instrument that needed a small repair and got a large one; and the career fantasy. To a man in his late thirties who had spent five years chasing an apprenticeship, moved his family across the country and was looking at a three-month programme at fifteen thousand dollars with no aid, the maker **Nick Lewis** gave the sentence this hobby runs on: **"Only go into this field as a profession if you can't live without it."**[4]

THE MAP · WHERE THE NEXT TWO PAGES GO

Page 16 is the gear and the wood: what a thumb plane costs, what the grades on a spruce top actually measure, and the one supplier in Stradivari's own valley that prints a density figure instead of a letter. **Page 17** is the culture and the money: the varnish wars, the mould that broke a beginner, what three years of school costs, and the resale cliff. Four words you need now — **the plates** (the two carved faces), **in the white** (finished, unvarnished), **the mould** (the form the ribs bend around), **graduation** (thinning the plates to final thickness, in tenths of a millimetre).

THE SCEPTIC · A MARKET WITH NO PRICES

The craft's own town square forbids commerce. A pinned Pegbox notice reads **"Re: For Sale postings are not allowed"**; the Auction Scroll says the same in capitals. There is a live thread titled **"Understanding appropriate pricing for lesser-known, undocumented luthiers"** because no price exists to look up. Even inside the trade the numbers are thin: a prospective apprentice described a shop with three full-time makers where "money is very inconsistent and low", and the forum's verdict on a claimed six-figure maker income was Lewis again — **"Probably abnormal."**[5]

2024

THE YEAR LUTHIERS MERCANTILE INTERNATIONAL, THE LONG-STANDING AMERICAN LUTHIER SUPPLY HOUSE, CLOSED. ITS OWN SITE NOW SAYS ONLY: "IN 2024 THEY CLOSED THEIR DOORS"[6]

SOURCES 1 Violin Making School of America tuition page and the Scuola Internazionale di Liuteria's own site, both read at source 25 October 2026; kit prices from International Violin Company's tonewood catalogue. 2 Forum and board statistics read directly off Maestronet's index and Pegbox pages on 25 October 2026. 3 Violin Society of America membership, competition and convention pages; the British Violin Making Association's own site; the Entente's own site. **The VSA publishes no total membership figure on any page read, and none is printed here.** 4 The thread "Is this normal? New to the field", 9 July 2026, read in full; handles and locations as the forum displays them. 5 Pinned notices on the Pegbox and the Auction Scroll, read at source; the income exchange from the same July thread. 6 Luthiers Mercantile International's own site. **Reddit refused this desk for the eleventh issue running, so r/Luthier does not appear in this desk and no sentiment from it is invented.**

THE DEEP END · THE WOOD AND THE TOOLS

Ciresa Fiemme prints a density figure where every rival catalogue prints a letter

The sawmill in Stradivari's own Val di Fiemme sells a grade I° violin top at €89 with 447 kilograms per cubic metre on the listing, while American catalogues grade the same wood from "plain" to "master" at US$53 to US$226.

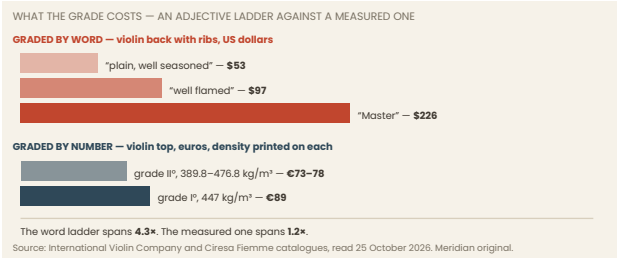
There is no universal tonewood grading standard, and the catalogues prove it by disagreeing. International Violin Company grades violin backs in plain English — **plain, better, flamed, well flamed, deeply flamed, master** — and the price climbs **US$53 to US$97 to US$226** on that basis alone. Drewbas offers "AA, AAA and Master Quality" and defines none of them. One German shop lists a top titled "Violin A" at a web address containing "aaa".[1]

Then there is **Ciresa Fiemme**, the sawmill in the Val di Fiemme the Cremonese logged. It uses no letters. It grades **I°** and **II°**, and for every single top it publishes the **seasoning year and the density in kilograms per cubic metre**: grade I° Fiemme spruce, cut 2018, **447 kg/m³, €89 excluding tax**; bear-claw figure at €107; grade II° between €73 and €78. **The one house that could trade hardest on provenance publishes a measurement instead of an adjective.**[2]

What the letter actually measures is figure, straightness and runout — how the wood will look, and how pleasant it is to carve. The forum's most measurement-driven member says so plainly. On a billet with bad runout, **Don Noon**: "Sound-wise, I doubt that the runout you have would have a significant effect. The main effect would be for working the wood... Also the aesthetics of a harlequin top." Then the honest coda: "I wouldn't use it... but I am not you, as I have a lifetime supply of split billets."[3]

> ***"Build it and see, maybe it'll be amazing. Or not. Violins often defy expectation."***

The tools are the opposite story: a short list, honestly priced, that barely changes. The thumb plane is the one object you cannot fake — an **Ibex finger plane is US$77** in Baltimore and **€119 including tax** in Bavaria, arched or flat sole, and you need both. A **toothed spare blade at US$26** is what lets you plane flamed maple without tearing it. A **Herdim scraper blade is US$5.60** and does more work than anything else on the bench, once you own a **US$34.50 burnisher** to turn its hook.[4]



Two houses, two ways of pricing the same species. The American catalogue's spread is a description of figure; the Italian sawmill's is a range of measured densities. **Backs and tops are different parts and are not directly comparable in price — the comparison here is between the two grading systems, not the two woods.**[1]

THE SCEPTIC · THE TAX ON NOT CHECKING

The same Mach One purfling cutter is **US$102 in Baltimore and €66.90 including German tax** — a thirty-five to forty per cent premium for buying it in the obvious place. The money pits are nameable: a Herdim cello multi peg shaver at **US$608**, a bass endpin reamer at **€594**, an f-hole drilling jig at **US$185** for a cut done with a knife for three hundred years. And the grade premium itself: IVC's back goes from US$53 to US$226 on descriptions of figure, while Ciresa's whole published spread between measured grades is about **€20**.[5]

€89

A GRADE I° VIOLIN TOP FROM THE SAWMILL IN STRADIVARI'S OWN VALLEY, DENSITY PRINTED ON THE LABEL. THE VALLEY THE CREMONESE LOGGED SELLS ITS WOOD ONLINE, BY THE NUMBER, FOR LESS THAN A GOOD DINNER FOR TWO[2]

SOURCES 1 International Violin Company's backs and tops catalogues and Drewbas Tonewood's own site, read 25 October 2026; the contradictory listing read on a German shop the same day. 2 Ciresa Fiemme's own violin catalogue, read at source: every listing carries grade, seasoning year, density and price excluding tax, and the figures here are quoted from it. 3 The thread "Should I use this top with runout", 16 August 2026, read in full; Deo Lawson's line in the pull quote is from the same thread. 4 Prices from International Violin Company, Metropolitan Music and Dictum, each read on its own catalogue page. **Workshop Heaven returned 404 on every tool category, so no Auriou or Ashley Iles price appears here.** 5 Both purfling-cutter prices read on the two retailers' own pages on the same day; the money-pit prices from the same catalogues. **Stewart-MacDonald, Howard Core and Lee Valley all refused this desk, so no price from any of them appears, and four suppliers in general circulation — Rivolta, Toneholz, Florinel Nita and Orcas Island — had no reachable site and are not listed.**

THE DEEP END · THE MOULD AND THE MONEY

MIT researchers built a Stradivari inside a computer that plays a Bach fugue

Published in npj Acoustics on 29 April, the model is built from the 1715 'Titian' — CT-scanned in 600 slices in September 2006 for a violin-makers' project run by a working maker, Sam Zygmuntowicz.

The cutting edge of this craft is twenty years long. In September 2006 the Strad3D project laser- and CT-scanned three instruments — the 1735 'Plowden' Guarneri, the 1734 'Willemotte' and the 1715 'Titian' Stradivari — under a maker rather than a physicist. On **29 April 2026** a team including a violin-making teacher published a computational 'Titian' with tensioned strings and full aerodynamic coupling that **plays music**, demonstrated on a Bach solo fugue and "Daisy Bell".[1]

Its honest finding is small. Including string pretension moves the instrument's modes by about **two to three decibels and two to three per cent**, and the paper claims only that it may save time in lutherie. That is roughly the scale serious acoustics can now resolve — and roughly the scale the tonewood grading market claims to sell, except the market sells it with an adjective. The geometry of those scanned instruments reaches the amateur bench as a **US$22 arching template**.[1]

The tool the community actually adopted this year is free. **CremonaCad**, released on 5 June by Andrew Argraves and open source, builds violin outlines from **intersecting arc segments** rather than Cartesian measurements — "a more historically accurate approach to design" — and exports mould patterns to PDF. Its thread ran to **177 replies**. **Dr. Mark** supplied the verdict: "It was only a matter of time. Next: StradCad!... Progress cannot be stopped."[2]

> *"It is a relaxing activity and I can quit at any moment."*

And the first ninety days cost about **US$1,250**. Thirty days reading the Pegbox and watching Davide Sora's bench videos, free. Then a Two Cherries six-piece palm set at **US$199**, two Ibex finger planes at US$77 each, a toothed blade, two Hock knives, four Herdim scraper blades at US$22.40, a burnisher, a Strad-model mould at **US$82.50**, a garland of spool clamps at US$110, a Ciresa top at €89 and a master-grade maple back at **US$189**. Defer the bending iron and the peg shaver.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE MOULD THAT BROKE A BEGINNER

On 29 July a member called *Pelayo*, five posts to his name, wrote: "I have tried, up to now, to cut **three molds** but I am always filing... It is imposible to me making a square cut." **Brad Dorsey**, 9,300 posts, gave the forum's bedside manner: it probably is not critical — and "If you are finding it this difficult to make the mold, I think you find making the instrument very challenging." **Don Noon** diagnosed it properly: only one surface needs to be flat and square, chalk-fit the rest, and "If you can't do that, you'll never be able to fit a neck to the body." Pelayo's reply is the best sentence in the hobby.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · FORTY HOURS FOR ONE PLATE

The only first-person figure anyone would give is from an amateur five instruments in: **"It probably takes me close to 40 hours to finish a top."** One plate — not the back, the ribs, the scroll, the neck, the varnish or the setup. The institutional answer is **3,900 clock hours** at Salt Lake City, **US$42,768** over three years, or **US$39,690** in Chicago. The same maker, on his fourth instrument: "right from the minute it held tune it's by far the best one." **Fourth.** And it cannot be sold, because the forum that is the market bans selling.[5]

NEXT DESCENTS

Competitive barbecue — offset smokers, and what a hand-built pit actually costs.

Marquetry — veneer, the donkey, and pictures made from sliced trees.

Origami — crease patterns, wet-folding, and the mathematicians who took it over.

SOURCES 1 Krishnadas, Liu, Campbell, Barnas and Makris, "Exploring the behavior of a strung computational Stradivarius violin", *npj Acoustics*, 29 April 2026, read at source; the September 2006 scanning, the three instruments and the creative director from Strad3D's own site. The template price is International Violin Company's. **The two-to-three-decibel figure is reported in coverage of the paper rather than quoted from its abstract and is flagged as such.** 2 The CremonaCad release thread, 5 June to 12 October 2026, read in full, including the reply count and the quoted posts. 3 Every price read on its supplier's own catalogue page, 25 October 2026; the total is this magazine's own arithmetic. 4 The thread "Giving up with the mould", 29 July 2026, read in full; post counts as the forum displays them. 5 The hours figure from "Should I use this top with runout"; tuition from the two schools' own pages, the Chicago total being nine trimesters at the published rate. **Newark's site is behind a challenge page and no figure for it is printed.**

FITNESS · CREATINE AND COGNITION

A six-week creatine trial found no Stroop effect and led on a WHOOP score

Fifty-one perimenopausal women averaging 46 years trained twice a week and took creatine or placebo; Stroop times improved in every arm and the groups did not differ, and the positive finding is a WHOOP sleep-consistency score.

A trial published on **24 October** in the *European Journal of Applied Physiology* randomised **51 perimenopausal women, aged 46 plus or minus 5**, to creatine, placebo or a non-training control — arms of 18, 20 and 13. Five days of loading at 20 grams a day, then six weeks at about 4.5, alongside twice-weekly resistance training. Cognition was measured by Stroop, with prefrontal oxygenation read by near-infrared spectroscopy.[1]

The primary cognitive result is a null, and it is the one a reader cares about. **Stroop reaction time improved in both conditions — with no group differences.** Everybody got faster; creatine did nothing to performance. What moved was a surrogate: prefrontal oxygenation during the task rose **0.32 per cent** on creatine against a fall of 1.62 on placebo. **The standard deviation on both is 2.01 — six times the size of the creatine effect.** Blood flow to the forehead moved; the thinking did not.[1]

The headline finding is therefore the sleep one, and it is a brand. Not duration, not efficiency: **sleep consistency**, a proprietary composite, up **7.4 percentage points** against placebo at week six. The authors call their own work "this exploratory analysis" and report no confidence intervals anywhere, only standard deviations and p-values. General guidance, not medical advice.[1]

> ***"These analyses were not independently reproduced."***

To the paper's real credit, it says the rest out loud. One co-author **"is an employee of and holds stock options in WHOOP, Inc."**, the company whose wristband supplied the sleep metric. The disclosure continues: he **"exported the WHOOP data and performed the sleep and symptom analyses while blinded to the treatment groups; these analyses were not independently reproduced by an investigator without a WHOOP affiliation."** The senior author advises three creatine companies and holds equity in one. The company had no role in design or approval, and the code is public.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · MORE OBSERVATIONS THAN PARTICIPANTS

The meta-analysis that made creatine-and-cognition respectable has an arithmetic problem, and a commentary in *Frontiers in Nutrition* this April sets it out. Trials reporting several correlated outcomes from the same participants were entered as independent effect sizes — some with four or seven memory subtests each — so **the pooled analysis contains more observations than unique randomised people**, "artificially inflating precision and statistical power". The same flaw was raised against an earlier review; on reanalysis **the memory effect was no longer significant except in older adults**. The European Food Safety Authority agreed in 2024.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE SOFT MEASURE MOVES, THE HARD ONE DOES NOT

A separate crossover trial — **14 physically active men**, 20 grams a day for a week, wrist actigraphy — found creatine improved **subjective** sleep quality but **did not affect sleep latency, sleep efficiency or total sleep time**. Same pattern. **Dipa Kamdar** of Kingston University, in The Conversation, ranks creatine among the more useful supplements she reviewed but calls the postmenopausal evidence "mixed" and says that on brain and mood "more research is needed specifically in menopausal women". Reddit refused this desk for the eleventh issue running.[4]

0.32 ± 2.01

THE CREATINE GROUP'S CHANGE IN PREFRONTAL OXYGENATION, IN PER CENT. THE DISPERSION IS SIX TIMES THE EFFECT — AND THIS IS THE TRIAL'S POSITIVE COGNITIVE FINDING[1]

SOURCES 1 Baker, DelBiondo, Kelly, Johnson, Grosicki and Smith-Ryan, "Creatine supplementation effects on cognition, sleep, and menopause symptoms in response to six weeks of high-intensity resistance training in perimenopausal females", *European Journal of Applied Physiology*, online 24 October 2026, registered at ClinicalTrials.gov, read in full through the National Library of Medicine. **Published two days ago with no independent coverage; single-sourced to the paper and flagged as such. The reading of the dispersion against the effect is this magazine's own.** 2 Both disclosures quoted verbatim from the paper's own competing-interests statement. 3 Citherlet, commentary in *Frontiers in Nutrition*, 10 April 2026, read in full; the author declares no competing interests. The reanalysis and the regulator's 2024 conclusion are reported within it. 4 Ben Maaoui and colleagues, *Nutrients*, 2025, through the National Library of Medicine; Kamdar in The Conversation, 23 April 2026. **Examine.com returned 429. General guidance, not medical advice.**

THE DIARY · BEFORE THE YEAR TURNS

Kenshi Yonezu added a second Singapore night for his first world tour

The GHOST tour plays the Indoor Stadium on 29 and 30 January; Diana Krall takes two Esplanade nights at S$88 to S$268 in November, and the January sumo basho opens its advance sale on 5 December.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

24–25 Nov ★ **Diana Krall · Mosaic Music Series**
ESPLANADE CONCERT HALL, 8PM · ON SALE · S$88–268, CONCESSION FROM S$74.80 · 75 MINUTES, NO INTERVAL

20–29 Nov **Kalaa Utsavam · Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · ON SALE · FROM S$39.60 · SACHIN–JIGAR'S SINGAPORE DEBUT; FREE OPENING PERFORMANCE

28–29 Nov **BABYMONSTER · CHOOM World Tour**
INDOOR STADIUM, 6PM · **RE-CHECKED 26 OCT: STILL NOT SOLD OUT** · S$168–358

3–6 Dec **Voices · A Festival of Song**
ESPLANADE · ON SALE · FROM S$28 · VOICE BAND EXIT'S SINGAPORE DEBUT; WORKSHOPS FROM S$15

21–24 Jan **ART SG 2027**
MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO · **TWO-FOR-ONE ENDS 24 NOV, 23:59** · FRIDAY S$40, WEEKEND S$44 · UNDER-16S FREE

29–30 Jan ★ **Kenshi Yonezu · GHOST World Tour**
INDOOR STADIUM · **SECOND NIGHT ADDED 22 OCT** · NO PRICE ON THE LABEL'S PAGE

23 JAN **Young K · YOUNGEST Solo Tour**
THE STAR THEATRE, 5PM · ON SALE · S$148–298 · VIP BY 14 JAN ENTERS THE SIGNED-POSTER DRAW

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

4–6 Dec ★ **Clockenflap 2026**
CENTRAL HARBOURFRONT, HONG KONG · ON SALE · QUEENS OF THE STONE AGE, HAYLEY WILLIAMS, KESHI, SLOWDIVE

3–7 Dec **Wonderfruit 2026**
SIAM COUNTRY CLUB, CHONBURI · PASSES ON SALE; **A NOVEMBER WAITLIST RUNS 3–9 NOV** · CABINS SELL BEFORE TICKETS

10–24 Jan ★ **Grand Sumo · Hatsu Basho**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **ADVANCE SALE OPENS SAT 5 DEC** · NOVEMBER'S FUKUOKA BASHO IS SOLD OUT ON EVERY DAY

2–26 Jan **Shinshun Kabuki · Asakusa Public Hall**
TOKYO · **TICKETS OPEN 21 NOV, 10AM JST** · SHINKABUKIZA'S RUN OPENS 30 NOV, SAME HOUR

31 Oct–28 Mar **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI HILLS · OPENS THIS WEEK · HER LARGEST TOKYO SURVEY IN YEARS

4–11 Feb **Sapporo Snow Festival 2027**
ŌDORI, TSUDOME, SUSUKINO · FREE · **2027 DATES NOW ON THE ORGANISER'S OWN SITE**; THE ENGLISH MIRROR STILL SHOWS 2025

6–13 Feb **Otaru Snow Light Path, 29th**
OTARU CANAL, HOKKAIDŌ · FREE · OVERLAPS SAPPORO 6–11 FEB — ONE TRIP, BOTH

PLANNING NOTES · FOUR DATES THAT CLOSE

21 November, 10am Japan time opens Asakusa's New Year kabuki — the cheapest serious way into the form, and it goes. **24 November, 23:59** ends ART SG's two-for-one, which is quoted per pair, so the move is to buy two and go twice. **5 December** is the hard one: advance sale for the January Tokyo basho, and the warning is that the November Fukuoka tournament is already **sold out on every single day** with no same-day sales. If 5 December slips, Osaka in March opens on 6 February and is the easier room.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THIS PAGE COULD NOT CONFIRM

Three things are off the page rather than on it. **Christmas Wonderland has published no 2026 dates** — its own site still serves a 2025 closure page. **The Singapore marathon's site still describes the 2025 race. Chingay 2027 still has no dates**, and the 2027 volunteer link in its own navigation returns a 404. Two dead entries stand: the **Dee Dee Bridgewater** duo of 29 October remains titled "[CANCELLED]" in Esplanade's own listing, and **Post Malone** appears nowhere. On sourcing: SISTIC renders zero results, Ticketmaster Singapore, the Sports Hub and Burpple all returned 403, so **BTS's four December nights are reported as resale-only rather than listed.**[2]

SOURCES 1 Every row above was verified against a promoter, venue or organiser page rather than an aggregator, read 25–26 October 2026: Esplanade's own festival and series pages for Krall, Kalaa Utsavam and Voices; Live Nation Singapore's event pages for BABYMONSTER and Young K; ART SG's own ticket page for the deadline and the under-16 policy; **the artist's own label for the Yonezu dates and the added second night, the label carrying no prices**; the official sumo ticketing portal and the Sumo Association's own front page for both tournaments and the Fukuoka sell-out; Kabukiweb for both January runs; the Mori Art Museum's exhibitions page; the Snow Festival organiser's own site; Sapporo's tourism page for Otaru; Clockenflap's and Wonderfruit's own pages. 2 The three dead entries verified at the organisers' own sites on 26 October; the Bridgewater cancellation re-read in Esplanade's own series listing. **ART SG's own tickets page misprints its dates as January 2026; its homepage is correct and is what is printed here.**

THE TABLE · FOUR NEW ROOMS

BAO London's founders open BFF at New Bahru on 11 November for seven weeks

The S$6.50 Chicken Chopper went through 140 iterations and the brand calls the Singapore run a "Test Lab"; a Hougang window pizzaiolo has taken a shop at Alkaff Crescent, and an air-force cook is selling wok-fried spaghetti at S$7.

The founders of BAO London — Erchen Chang and Shing Tat and Wai Ting Chung, who began with a gua bao stall at Netil Market and now run seven London sites — open **BFF** at New Bahru on **11 November**, a seven-week run to 28 December, with The Lo & Behold Group. It is part Taiwanese fast-food counter, part convenience store. The **Chicken Chopper at S$6.50** leaves the bone in as a handle, uses a soymilk batter and tapioca coating, and was refined over **140 iterations**. **Nobody in Singapore has eaten one yet, and no praise here is attributed to this outlet.**[1]

JR Pizzeria is the better story. **Joachim Loo**, 24, left school after the PSLE, entered a vocational programme at fourteen, and cooked at Relish, Wild Rocket, Swissôtel and three-Michelin-starred Zen before teaching himself dough. He started in May 2025 selling through the window of his family's Hougang flat, and moved out because of corridor queues, oven heat in the flat and strangers at the door. The pesto at **S$30.50** is the bestseller; the margherita at S$16 is what one reviewer called the standout. Waits run **forty to forty-five minutes** at peak.[2]

Woksta opened on **5 October** at ABC Brickworks, one man at the wok. **Henry Yong**, 34, spent over a decade in the air force, then joined Dill's founding kitchen team in 2024; he took a hawker stall rather than a restaurant to be home for two small children. The premise is wok hei on spaghetti, on a house coconut-onion sauce cooked with salted fish and ikan bilis. Laksa seafood **S$10**, curry fried chicken S$7. It sells out between **1.30 and 1.40pm**, weekdays, lunch only.[3]

And **7 Paintings** arrived at Conrad Singapore Marina Bay in October: a seven-course dinner built around Michelangelo, Banksy, Picasso, Pollock, Warhol, Dalí and van Gogh, with projections and a course you spray-paint yourself. It is a franchise — the format runs in sixty cities — with a local kitchen: executive chef **Thomas Jakobi** created the Singapore-exclusive dishes, a flamed Murray River cod and an upgraded wagyu. **Classic S$190++, Premium S$230++.** A Wednesday session is added from 1 November.[4]

THE BUZZ · WHAT IS ACTUALLY KNOWN

JR Pizzeria has one proper notice — warm, no score, singling out the margherita and calling the wings an excellent companion. Against that: OpenRice is "waiting for its first review", Pawwhere shows none and Burpple returned nothing. **Woksta** has one review, favourably disposed and usefully critical: the wok hei is **subtler than the premise promises**, and the curry is sweeter than expected, closer to a Japanese curry than a Singaporean one — and that review discloses it was a hosted tasting. **7 Paintings** has an experience write-up and a launch piece; **no local critic has filed a verdict on the food.**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THREE OF THESE FOUR ARE UNJUDGED

Be plain about it: **one of these rooms has not opened, two have one review each, and the fourth has none on the cooking.** BFF's own site calls the run a "Test Lab", a candid way of saying the menu is not finished; a permanent site is targeted for 2027. At **S$190++ a head** the Conrad dinner is selling a format — the only two dishes you cannot eat in the other fifty-nine cities are the cod and the wagyu. The queue is doing more talking than the critics are, and the queue is not a verdict.[5]

NEW BAHRU · ALKAFF CRESCENT · ABC BRICKWORKS · TOO NEW TO CALL · LUNCH ONLY

S$7

A PLATE OF CURRY-FRIED-CHICKEN WOK SPAGHETTI AT ABC BRICKWORKS, AGAINST S$190 BEFORE SERVICE CHARGE FOR SEVEN COURSES AT THE CONRAD. BOTH OPENED IN SINGAPORE THIS MONTH[3]

SOURCES 1 BFF's own site and BAO London's, plus announcement coverage of 23–24 October, all read at source 26 October 2026; the dates, address, prices and the 140 iterations are the brand's own. **The two published closing times differ by half an hour — the brand says 10.30pm, a preview says 10pm.** 2 A first-look review of 23 October read in full, with the chef's biography and the queue times as reported; prices from the restaurant's own listings. **No operator has published an exact opening day, so the month is given and not a date.** 3 Review of 5–23 October read at source; the opening date, the prices and the sell-out window are as reported. **Neither Woksta nor BFF claims halal certification and none is asserted here either way.** 4 The operator's Singapore page and the hotel's, plus two local write-ups, read at source; the session schedule and the 1 November addition are the operator's own. 5 Reviews as cited above; the hosted-tasting disclosure is the reviewer's own. **Burpple returned 403, Instagram 429 and SETH LUI 403, so no social sentiment was read and none is invented.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · KOPDES MERAH PUTIH

Indonesia borrowed 240 trillion rupiah to build eighty thousand Red-and-White cooperatives

Four state banks lent it to one company, PT Agrinas Pangan Nusantara; 58.03 per cent of the 2026 Village Fund now services the debt, and the programme's own live dashboard recorded 56.68 billion rupiah of sales for the year.

In Desa Jejeruk, in Blora regency in Central Java, there is a new building twenty metres by thirty. It has shelves. It has display gondolas, delivered. It has nothing on them. Jefryanto, the chairman of the cooperative it belongs to, told a local paper that **the keys to every finished building in his area are held by Koramil Blora Kota** — the sub-district military command — and will pass to the village's resident soldier at a formal handover. He was not involved in the construction. Nobody told him when to stock the shop, or who tops up the electricity meter.[1]

His building is one of roughly eighty thousand. On **27 March 2025** President Prabowo Subianto signed Presidential Instruction No. 9, ordering a **Koperasi Desa/Kelurahan Merah Putih** — a Red-and-White Village Cooperative — in every village and urban ward in Indonesia, inside a year. By late June, **80,319 villages** had held formation meetings; by July the cooperatives minister said more than **81,000** had legal personality.[2]

Then look at how it was paid for, because that is where it stops being a cooperative revival. The money did not go to eighty thousand cooperatives. Under a later instruction and a finance-ministry regulation, the four state banks extended a **240 trillion rupiah syndicated facility — about fourteen and a half billion US dollars — to a single borrower**: PT Agrinas Pangan Nusantara, a state company, at six per cent over seventy-two months, with a three-billion-rupiah ceiling per outlet. Agrinas builds the shops. The villages receive the buildings.[3]

One borrower. Two of the four banks above the single-borrower limit.

By the banks' own June 2026 reports, **each** of the four had lent Agrinas more than fifty trillion rupiah. Bank Mandiri's exposure equals **22 per cent of consolidated core capital**; Bank Negara Indonesia's equals **35** — against a standard single-borrower limit of twenty-five per cent of tier-one capital. One state company, four state banks, and a concentration that the prudential rulebook exists to prevent.[3]

And the repayment is where the politics is. A finance-ministry regulation effective 1 April 2026 has instalments and interest **deducted monthly from regional transfers** by the central government, directly. A second, effective 12 February, assigns **58.03 per cent of the 2026 Village Fund** — 34.57 trillion rupiah of a 60.57 trillion ceiling — to the cooperatives. Villages keep about twenty-six trillion for everything else they do.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE STATE SAYS IT CANNOT GO BAD

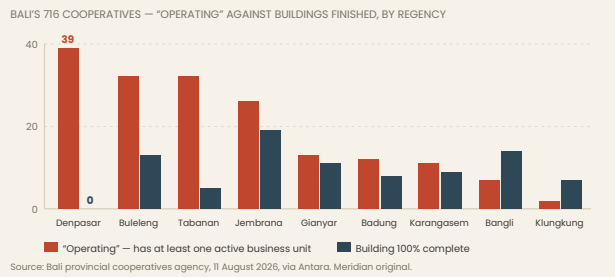
The official answer is that sovereign backing settles the question. **Dony Oskaria**, who heads the state-enterprise body, on 7 September: "the most secure credit is one guaranteed by the state… it's impossible for it to go bad." Finance minister **Purbaya Yudhi Sadewa**, asked whether September's instalment was safe: **"it's safe, the minister is Purbaya."** A banking analyst adds the technical defence: average capital adequacy above seventeen per cent, and a late loan takes ninety days to become even a special-mention one. **All of that is true, and none of it is about whether the shops sell anything.**[5]

SOURCES 1 *Radar Kudus* via Jawa Pos, 22 April 2026, read at source: the building, the empty shelves, the keys held by the sub-district military command and the chairman's account of what he was not told. 2 Presidential Instruction No. 9 of 2025, read on the state secretariat's own site; formation counts from the finance ministry's data as published by Katadata's data desk, 3 July 2025, and from the cooperatives minister as reported by the Jakarta Globe. 3 The 240 trillion facility, its terms and the per-bank exposures from Katadata's investigation of 2 September 2026, which reads them out of the banks' own June 2026 financial reports; the loan terms corroborated at IDX Channel, 6 August. **Agrinas has published no financial statements of any kind.** 4 Both finance-ministry regulations read at the ministry's own legal-documentation portal. **Note the government's own arithmetic does not close: 34.57 of 60.57 trillion is 57.1 per cent, not the 58.03 the regulation states. Both figures are the state's.** 5 Oskaria and Purbaya via Katadata and Kabar Bursa, September 2026; the state secretary via Antara. **Several Indonesian outlets returned 403, so no Indonesian primary document beyond the two regulations and the instruction was read at source.**

On **25 September 2026** the first instalment fell due: **37.7 trillion rupiah** of principal and interest. Four days before, the finance ministry said it had received no invoice from the banks, and that payment required Agrinas to lodge a work-acceptance document, reviewed by the state auditor. By 1 October a deputy minister was saying the money was "ready" and already sitting at the banks. The bill was still unpaid. **The state could not pay itself, because its own auditor had verified only 8.1 trillion rupiah of construction against the amount due.**[1]

Against which, set the sales. The programme runs a live management-information system called Simkopdes, and the state publishes the number that indicts it. Pulled at 10:25 on **14 July 2026**, total transaction value for the whole country, for the year to date, was **56.68 billion rupiah** from 53,767 transactions. Against a 240 trillion facility that is **0.024 per cent**. Spread across roughly eighty-three thousand cooperatives it is about **680,000 rupiah each** — some forty US dollars, for seven months.[2]

What the shops sell is the second tell. The top two lines by value are **NPK Phonska fertiliser at 15.09 billion rupiah** and **urea at 11.27 billion**. Fertiliser alone is 26.36 billion — **46.5 per cent of everything the programme has ever sold**. Then cooking oil at 3.63 billion, subsidised rice at 2.45, and cooking gas at 480 million. This is not a retail network. It is a subsidised-input distribution channel with a shopfront attached.[2]



Denpasar reports **thirty-nine cooperatives operating and not one finished building**; Bangli has fourteen buildings and seven operating. The provincial agency's own definition does the work: operating means "at least one active business unit".[3]

Bali is the one clean regional dataset, and it is a lesson in definitions. The province has **716 cooperatives**, one per village and ward. **86 buildings are finished. 174 are "operating"** — a number that exceeds the buildings because the provincial agency's head defines operating as having "at least one active business unit". Across the first half of 2026 those 716 cooperatives turned over **1.28 billion rupiah in total**, about seventy-seven thousand US dollars, reported by the provincial treasury rather than by any audited account.[3]

"*The only obstacle is stock.*"

Underneath the national figure the build is uneven in a way the dashboard cannot show. In **Blora regency**, in January 2026, the local military commander put it at **295 villages, 214 sites under construction and four finished**, with **81 sites blocked for want of land** and two villages excluded altogether because a dam will submerge them. Overall progress was reported at seventy-two per cent.[4]

And where the shops do open, the problem is supply rather than demand. In Wonogiri, Central Java, the chairman of one cooperative told a local paper that operations run smoothly and **"the only obstacle is stock"** — pre-ordered cooking oil and subsidised rice that never arrive, across sixty-three outlets in the regency — and that **two Agrinas field officers collect the day's takings from every outlet each afternoon**. In Bojonegoro, East Java, **eighty per cent of the regency's 85 outlets stopped operating on the same day**, 3 July 2026: staff promised 1.2 to 1.4 million rupiah a month had received **76,000**.[5]

The managers are the last piece. Thirty thousand posts were advertised in April; **639,732 people applied** and 483,648 passed the administrative screen. The successful ones are not cooperative employees. They are **fixed-term state-company staff on two-year contracts**, and before taking up their posts roughly thirty thousand of them were sent to **67 military education units** for thirty days of basic military training followed by fifteen days of management. **Five died between 17 and 26 June 2026**, of cardiac arrest, heat stroke and tuberculosis. A parliamentarian put the training's cost above a trillion rupiah, about forty-five million a head.[6]

SOURCES 1 Katadata, three dated reports of 3 September and 1 October 2026, read at source. **This desk's last verified position is 1 October: unpaid. Whether it has since been settled could not be established, and nothing later is asserted.** 2 Katadata's extract from the programme's own Simkopdes dashboard, timestamped 10:25 on 14 July 2026; the product breakdown is the dashboard's. **The percentages are this magazine's own arithmetic on those numbers.** 3 Bali provincial cooperatives agency via Antara Bali, 11 August 2026, for the counts and the definition; the turnover from the provincial treasury office, 29 July, confirmed in the same unit at a second outlet. **A treasury extract, not an audited account.** 4 Times Indonesia, 29 January 2026, read at source; the district commander is on the record for every count. 5 *Radar Solo* via Jawa Pos, 18 July 2026, and DetikFinance, 9 July, both read at source. **A second outlet gives Bojonegoro as 54 outlets closed rather than 80 per cent of 85; it refused this desk, so the figure read at source is the one printed.** 6 Applicant and screening figures via Infobank News, 4 May 2026; contract status via Medcom; the training, the units and the five deaths from Katadata's report of 27 June, which names each of the five; the cost estimate is a named member of parliament's own.

Indonesia has done this before, with the same instruments and almost the same words. Presidential Instruction No. 4 of **1973** created the **Koperasi Unit Desa** — a cooperative in every village unit, with directed cheap credit, a monopoly on subsidised fertiliser distribution and a mandate to buy the harvest. It worked for a while: Indonesia reached rice self-sufficiency in 1984 and was decorated for it. At peak there were **more than nine thousand** such cooperatives with millions of members.[1]

About **5,400 of them ended up *mati suri*** — in suspended animation, the standard Indonesian phrase for a cooperative that exists on paper and does nothing. The epitaph came from the state's own former director-general of cooperatives: for twenty years they had been "developed and allowed to grow as a flawed organisation", and the trillions spent neither raised farmers' welfare nor strengthened the cooperatives. A study of their management concluded that their independence stayed weak **because they functioned as extensions of government**.[1]

Mati suri. Suspended animation: a cooperative that exists on paper and does nothing.

There is a closer precedent still. In 1998 the farm-credit scheme **Kredit Usaha Tani** disbursed **8.3 trillion rupiah** through nearly five thousand cooperatives and non-governmental organisations. **2.59 trillion has ever been repaid.** The rest went bad — roughly 5.7 trillion unrecovered. The structure was the same: state money, routed through a cooperative form, to buy agricultural inputs, with repayment nobody could enforce because the borrower was in some sense the lender.[2]

The parallel is exact in mechanism and differs only in scale and speed. Both are state programmes wearing a cooperative's name, funded by directed credit, administered by people the state appoints, and sustained by a monopoly on subsidised inputs — fertiliser is 46.5 per cent of everything the new one has ever sold. But the old one took a decade to reach nine thousand units. The new one claimed eighty thousand in sixteen months, and where Kredit Usaha Tani lost 5.7 trillion rupiah, the facility here is **240**.[2]

What makes this an Undercurrent rather than a scandal is where the money came from. Village Funds were the signature decentralisation of post-Suharto Indonesia: money sent straight to elected village councils, the one reform that reliably moved power downwards. In Tuban, East Java, village heads now keep two budgets — one with the full fund, one without the 58 per cent — because no technical guidance has arrived and they cannot tell which is real. **Warsito**, head of Sugihan, simply left the money out: every rupiah in and out needs an accountability report, and he will not record money he cannot account for.[3]

So the argument is this. **Indonesia has not revived the cooperative; it has rebuilt the village state, and financed it by mortgaging the one reform that had transferred power downwards.** The proof is in the plumbing: one borrower, four banks, two of them over the single-borrower limit; instalments garnished monthly from regional transfers; managers on two-year state contracts who were sent to army depots first; and, against all of it, 56.7 billion rupiah of sales, nearly half of it subsidised fertiliser. The real product was never groceries. It was a central channel into eighty thousand villages — and the villages are paying for the pipe.[4]

The economists have moved from warning to asking for a stop. A Jakarta think tank modelled cumulative default risk at **85.96 trillion rupiah** over six years. **M. Rizal Taufikurahman** of INDEF names the hazard precisely: the legal debtor is a company, not the state, so routing repayment through the budget means that "when instalments are guaranteed through the APBN, banks' incentive to assess project feasibility becomes weak". On 17 September **Lili Yang Ing**, secretary general of the International Economic Association, said the programme should be **temporarily halted** while its viability is assessed. Prabowo's own defence is the strongest version of the case against the status quo: the Village Fund, he has said, did not reach ordinary people for ten years. That is why the money is being spent on assets instead. It is also why the assets have no keys.[5]

SOURCES 1 Good News From Indonesia's account of the Koperasi Unit Desa, 17 June 2026, read at source: the 1973 instruction, the peak count, the roughly 5,400 *mati suri*, the former director-general's assessment and the management study it cites. 2 Kontan, 11 April 2017, read at source, for the 8.3 trillion disbursed and the 2.59 trillion repaid; **the 5.7 trillion unrecovered is this magazine's own subtraction.** 3 Jawa Pos, 27 April and 1 May 2026, read at source: the Tuban village heads keeping two budgets, named and quoted, and the Pamekasan village secretary's account that the diversion was never explained. 4 The argument is this magazine's own, on the figures sourced on p21 and p22. 5 The default model from Katadata's data desk, 22 July 2025; Taufikurahman quoted via Jawa Pos, 7 April 2026; Lili Yang Ing via Katadata, 17 September 2026; Prabowo's defence as reported by the state information agency, 16 May 2026. **Several Indonesian business outlets returned 403 to this desk — among them the reporting that only about a hundred of eighty-two thousand cooperatives are fully operating, which is therefore not printed here.**

THE LAST WORD

The proxy

A watchmaker in Glashütte published twenty numbers about a new chronograph on Saturday: five hundred and fifty-six movement parts, forty-five jewels, a moon phase accurate to a hundred and twenty-two point six years. Not the price, in any currency, in any market. Not the mass, of a watch made entirely of platinum. Two journalists who held it were refused the figure and supplied their own, differing by a factor of two; within thirty-six hours a reader had converted one of those guesses into “according to the article… ten and a half ounces” (p10).

That is this issue. The United States Treasury could not measure what a model can do, so it deleted the threshold and kept hard numbers for everything else it regulates (p7). A laboratory published three benchmark scores and marked the memory requirement unavailable (p8). Meta will take four hundred and nineteen Singapore dollars today and not say what the thing weighs; the figure everyone repeats comes from a corporate reseller’s catalogue (p9). A trial’s cognitive test came out null, so its headline became a wristband company’s own sleep score, computed by its own employee (p18).

None of these is a lie. Each is a real number standing where a different real number should be, and in every case the substitute was chosen by the party with something to lose. The honourable exception is a sawmill in the Val di Fiemme that could sell provenance and sells density instead — four hundred and forty-seven kilograms per cubic metre, printed on the label (p16). Montaigne had the shape of it four hundred years ago, on page two. The field of imposture is things unknown; and nothing is so firmly believed as what we least know.

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SOURCES A note on method. This edition’s load-bearing figures were read where they are published: a proposed rule in the Federal Register’s own text, at five offsets across its two hundred and seventy-nine thousand characters, and the executive order behind it; a statute at Cornell; an unmerged pull request and an unanswered bug report on a model runtime’s tracker; a model card in raw form; a watchmaker’s product pages in three territories and its press release in full; a Treasury yield curve and its real counterpart, subtracted here; two Bureau of Labor Statistics releases; four papers through the National Library of Medicine; an Indonesian presidential instruction and two finance-ministry regulations; a sawmill’s catalogue; a forum’s own statistics pages; and promoter and venue pages for every dated event on p19. Six figures are this magazine’s own arithmetic and all six say so. Where a host refused us — **Reddit for the eleventh issue running; Reuters, the Associated Press, the Financial Times and CNBC; Lee Valley, Stewart-MacDonald and Workshop Heaven; Paul Sellers and Lost Art Press; Best Buy, B&H and SHI; SISTIC, Ticketmaster Singapore and Burpple; Singapore Statutes Online and NEA’s newsroom; CME’s FedWatch for the second issue running; and several Indonesian outlets** — the page says so rather than quietly substituting. **Every hero in this issue was opened and looked at before it was captioned.**